

The student is always right

It has been two weeks since Verushka Lieutenant-Duval has given a course at the University of Ottawa. She has been facing the storm for two weeks.

Posted on October 15, 2020 at 7:00 a.m.

<https://www.lapresse.ca/actualites/2020-10-15/l-etudiant-a-toujours-raison.php>

(This is a Google-translate version of the French original.)



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PRESS

The indictment is serious: racism in the classroom. The verdict could cost him his career. But the Quebec teacher did not have the right to attend her virtual trial.



PHOTO FROM VERUSHKA LIEUTENANT-DUVAL FACEBOOK ACCOUNT

Verushka Lieutenant-Duval

His students, you see, needed a *safe space*, a safe space, to discuss his plight quietly. Would they make him lose his course or not?

It happened Wednesday afternoon, on *Zoom*, in the presence of four University of Ottawa employees. All that was missing was the main party, who could only produce a letter of apology for any defense.

During the meeting, the employees offered the students to continue the session with another teacher. But some considered this sentence clearly insufficient.

"In the group, there are a few students who want the teacher's skin," recounts Jan-Léopold Munk, a retired teacher who signed up for the course for fun.

And who is devastated by what is happening at the University of Ottawa.

Verushka Lieutenant-Duval's course focuses on the representation of gender identities in the visual arts. On September 23, she gave an online lesson on *queer* theory to her students.

Originally, the term *queer* was an insult, she explained to them. The gay community has reappropriated the word and emptied it of its initial meaning to make it a powerful identity marker.

In scholarly language, this recovery is called "subversive resignification". There are other famous cases, the teacher explained to her students. In the United States, for example, the black community has reclaimed the racist insult *n *gger*.

M^{me} Lieutenant Duval has not said *n-word* to protect sensitive ears. As it was a question of citing the word as an example, in an educational context, she pronounced it in its entirety.

Discomfort on *Zoom*.

"A student told her: a white woman should never say that word, period", reports Jan-Léopold Munk.

The same evening, the teacher apologized by email to her students. She did not know. She didn't mean to hurt anyone. Then, she tried to open the debate.

"I invite you to address the matter next week to think about what is appropriate to deal with this word. Is it better not to pronounce it because it is sensitive? Doesn't silence lead to oblivion and the status quo? "

This is where everything went wrong.

Some students choked with indignation. "She gave the impression that it was something that could be debated," one of them told *Fulcrum*, the student newspaper at the University of Ottawa.

Think about it. A debate at the university. A teacher who offers her students to think in class. What an idea !

M^{me} Lieutenant Duval was duly punished for his heresy. A student posted her apology email on Twitter, prompting a surge of outraged responses by so much ignorance, callousness and... racism.

The context ? We do not want to know.

Freedom of education? Nothing to give a fuck. From now on, we want secure spaces to protect oneself from micro-attacks, not spaces of freedom to express oneself on all subjects without being pressured.

From now on, we prefer censorship.
We prefer to humiliate a teacher on Twitter.

"@UOttawa, Please teach your teachers not to say the *n-word* so I don't have to, THANKS! ! The student tweeted who broadcast the apology email. Another praised his "courage" and his "refusal to be complicit in this behavior in our classes."

I do not see any courage in this denunciation. I only see a display of righteous purity and mock indignation on Twitter.

It does not take much courage to throw your teacher to the wolves on social networks. Especially when you suspect that her university, terrified at the idea of being considered racist, will punish... the prof.

This is exactly what the University of Ottawa did by suspending ^{Ms.} Lieutenant-Duval and offering students a change of teacher for the rest of the session. She bent her back. Worse, she sided with the militants.

"This language was offensive and totally unacceptable in our classrooms and on our campus," Kevin Kee, dean of the arts faculty wrote to students.

What does he think of the context in which the word was spoken? Shouldn't the dean defend the freedom of teaching of his colleagues?

"Both the dean and the University have nothing to add," a spokesperson wrote to me. He could just as well have written to me that at the University of Ottawa, the client-student is always right.

At Concordia University too.

In August, [I wrote about a film teacher](#), Catherine Russell, victim of a similar cabal for having quoted in class the pamphlet of Pierre Vallières, *Nègres blancs d'Amérique*. M^{me} Russell no longer gives the course this year.

In the United States, teachers have received disciplinary sanctions for using the word taboo in a school context. Universities stubbornly refuse to separate things.

"When we make a racist use of the word to belittle, insult, terrorize people, it is terrible and that should be condemned", underlined in June Randall Kennedy, professor of law at Harvard University, [on the airwaves of CNN](#).

But when one uses this word to underline the problem of racism, it is another thing, added the African-American professor. In this case, everyone should be able to use it, regardless of their skin color. "It would be a terrible thing, in American culture, if you put a racial line on who can say what. "

Dany Laferrière said much the same thing about the word "nigger" last week [on Culture Prime](#) : "Anyone can use it. We know when we are insulted, when someone uses a word to humiliate or crush you. We also know when it's another job. "

We know, because it's obvious.

The absurdity of all these matters is obvious. The cowardice and patronage of universities too. As long as you don't hide your face, nor drape yourself in its virtue.